

Democratic Backsliding in Latin America

How has electoral democracy changed globally and across selected Latin American countries between 2010 and 2023?

Ally Denton

American University

Overview

Democratic backsliding has become a central concern in international affairs. As such, this project examines global change in electoral democracy from 2010–2023, with a focus on variation across four Latin American countries.

Central Findings

- Democratic trajectories vary across countries due to differences in domestic leadership and external political and economic conditions.
- Global electoral democracy has declined modestly over the 2010–2023 period.
- Latin American cases show divergent trajectories, with both decline and improvement depending on the country.

Data

Dataset: Varieties of Democracy

- The dataset is structured as country-year panel data, with one observation per country-year.
- For this project, I am specifically looking at the span of 2010-2023 to try and optimize the data available.
- The Data will cover all countries that have data over this time period and also zoom in on four Latin American cases: Venezuela, Brazil, Ecuador, El Salvador.
 - These cases were chosen to reflect variation in regime type, economic performance, and political stability.
- The core variable for this project is:
 - the v2x_polyarchy variable (the Electoral Democracy Index)
 - The variable measures the extent to which the ideal of electoral democracy in its fullest sense is achieved.
 - The variable itself uses a 0-1 scale with 0 indicating low electoral democracy and 1 indicating high electoral democracy.

Trends in Overall Democracy Over Time

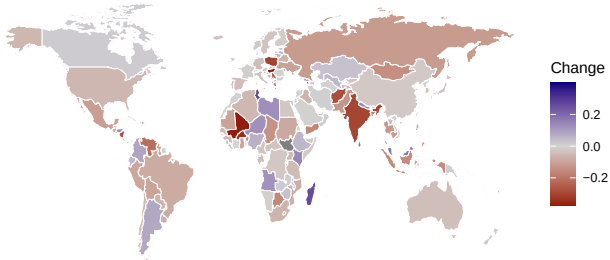
Table 1: Average Electoral Democracy over Time

year	mean
2010	0.52
2023	0.49

- Based on Table 1, electoral democracy in the world on average has seen a decrease of .031 points on the electoral democracy index in the past decade.

Electoral Democracy Throughout the World

Red = Backsliding | Blue = Improvement



Source: V-Dem

Figure 1: Change in Electoral Democracy across the World (2010–2023)

- The global pattern indicates a small decline in electoral democracy over the period, though outcomes differ significantly across countries and regions.

Zooming in on the Latin American Cases

Table 2: Average Electoral Democracy over Time

country_name	2010	2023
Brazil	0.87	0.79
Ecuador	0.59	0.64
El Salvador	0.62	0.38
Venezuela	0.42	0.21

- Looking at Table 2, the average electoral democracy does decrease for the majority of these cases.
- Ecuador is the main exception, showing a net increase over the period.
- Brazil remains relatively high on the electoral democracy scale despite mild fluctuation.

The Democracy Trends across Latin America over Time

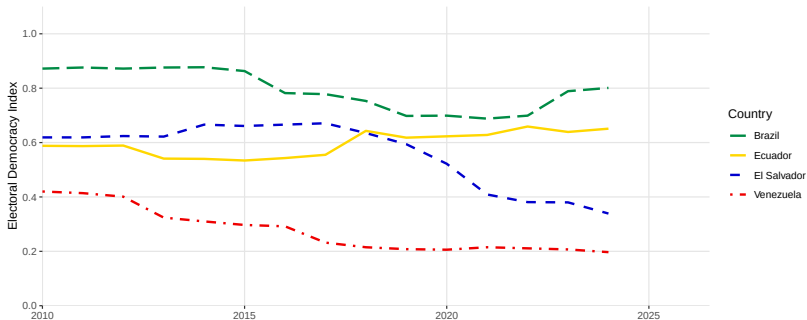


Figure 2: Democratic Trajectories in Latin America from 2010 to 2023

- Looking at Figure 2, the Latin American cases do not follow a uniform regional pattern.
 - Venezuela and El Salvador exhibit sustained declines in electoral democracy, while Brazil and Ecuador show more variation, including periods of recovery or relative improvement.

Conclusion

- Overall, the evidence suggests a small decline in electoral democracy globally between 2010 and 2023, though the magnitude of change is limited.
- At the regional level, Latin America does not follow a single trajectory.
 - Venezuela and El Salvador show sustained declines.
 - Brazil and Ecuador display more mixed trajectories, including periods of improvement.

Overall, these findings highlight that democratic change is not uniform across countries or regions. Rather, electoral democracy evolves through distinct national trajectories, even within the same geographic region.